

Bison bison

American bison



Length 7–11 ft (2.1–3.5 m)
Tail 1–2 ft (30–60 cm)
Weight 770–2,200 lb (350–1,000 kg)
Population 500,000
Status Near threatened



Also known as the American buffalo, the American bison is massively built, but also deceptively tall, with shoulder heights reaching 6½ft (2 m). Despite its huge bulk, the bison can run at speeds of up to 37 mph (60 kph). Its sense of hearing and smell are excellent, and essential for detecting danger. Bison spend much of their time grazing and browsing, in loose groups, with rest periods for ruminating. Adult females and their young live in hierarchical herds, which are led by a dominant female. Males usually live apart in bachelor groups and only join females during the mating season. Bison are not territorial, and migration is dictated by season change and adequate food supply. A subspecies, *B. bison athabasca*, is recognized and known as the Wood buffalo. Over a dozen wild herds now exist, but the species still occupies less than 1 percent of its former range.

MALES BATTLE FOR SUPREMACY



During the mating season, male bison will fight fiercely for the possession of females, usually by head-to-head ramming. Females wanting to mate with the dominant bull gallop about to incite competition between rival males.

CONSERVATION

Despite once numbering around 50 million, the American bison is now virtually extinct in the wild, largely due to widespread commercial hunting since the arrival of European settlers. Although subsequent conservation efforts have led to a significant increase in numbers, most American bison are either captive or have come from captive stock. Yellow Stone National Park (USA) and Wood Buffalo National Park (Canada) are among the few places in which wild herds survive.



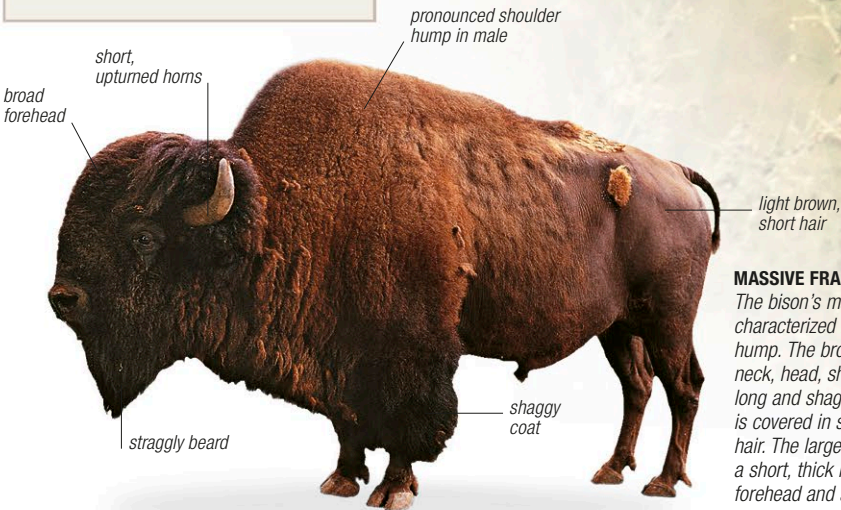
GRAZING MIGRANT

In the days of the free-roaming herds, bison would make annual migrations of hundreds of miles along traditional routes. However, of a current total population of 500,000 bison, only a very small fraction of these animals roam free in herds, and then only within the 37-mile (60-km) boundaries of the national parks.



WINTER COATS

Although bison are associated with the warm, dry plains of the American West, they are also found in mountainous regions, where they may experience extreme temperatures. In fact, winters offer bison few problems, since their heavy coats and thick manes protect them from the ice and cold.



MASSIVE FRAME

The bison's massive build is characterized by the towering shoulder hump. The brownish black hair on the neck, head, shoulders, and forelegs is long and shaggy, but the rest of the body is covered in shorter and lighter-colored hair. The large and heavy head sits on a short, thick neck, and features a wide forehead and straggly bearded chin.